into a new army, the Israel Defense Forces (IDF). Unfortunately, the few armored vehicles that Haganah had possessed had almost all been destroyed during the civil war. The new IDF had no effective combat aircraft, no heavy artillery, and no tanks. Even small arms were in short supply. As a rush of new recruits joined the IDF (Jewish refugees were arriving in Israel at the rate of around 10,000 each month), it was estimated that only around one in three had any type of weapon at all. A priority for the new state was building up its armed forces in order to repulse the expected Arab attack.

The need for tanks was a particularly urgent priority. Three World War II vintage M4 Sherman tanks were assembled from scrap left behind in British ordnance depots. Two British soldiers also stole a pair of operational British Cromwell tanks from a depot in Haifa, smashed through the gates, and delivered these to the IDF. These five tanks would form the only available IDF tank force when the war began.

Yet even before the creation of the new state, senior officials in Israel had been negotiating to purchase weapons from other sources. While the British mandate was in force, it was not possible to bring these to Israel, but almost immediately after midnight on May 14, deliveries of desperately needed weapons began to arrive. Israeli agents in Europe had concluded an arms deal with France that included artillery, light tanks, and mortars, and these began to arrive almost as soon as the British blockade ended.

One critical issue was that the IDF lacked the transport aircraft that would be needed to bring arms into Israel. In a secret operation named Yekum Purkan, officials had been negotiating for the purchase of a number of transport aircraft from the United States. This led to the acquisition of several Lockheed C-69 Constellation and C-45 Curtiss Commando aircraft. While these would help to bring in vital supplies, the purchase of fighters and bombers proved much more difficult as this was controlled by international regulations.

The single most important arms deal of all was concluded with Czechoslovakia. In late 1947, a Jewish Czech lawyer, Dr. Otto Felix, visited David Ben-Gurion. He explained that the Czech foreign minister, Jan Masaryk, was sympathetic to the creation of a Jewish homeland. He also explained that Czechoslovakia was critically short of cash but that the country had a number of arms factories and that